

AI Tools Often Used for Fake Product Reviews

Artificial intelligence (AI) tools that permit people to produce online reviews have put sellers, service providers and buyers in unfamiliar territory, public protection groups and researchers say.

False, or fake, reviews have long appeared on many popular websites such as Amazon and Yelp. The reviews are often traded on private social media groups between fake review dealers and businesses willing to pay. Sometimes, businesses get good reviews in exchange for offering buyers rewards such as gift cards.

But AI tools, popularized by OpenAI's ChatGPT, permit people to produce reviews faster and in greater numbers, technology industry experts say.

FILE - This photo illustration shows the ChatGPT logo at an office in Washington, DC, on March 15, 2023. (Photo by Stefani Reynolds / AFP)

Where are AI-generated reviews appearing?

Fake reviews are found across a wide range of industries, from e-commerce and travel to services such as home repairs, medical care and music lessons.

The Transparency Company is a technology company and public protection group that uses software to detect fake reviews. The company said it started to see AI-generated reviews appear in large numbers in mid-2023. The reviews have increased quickly ever since.

For a recently released report, The Transparency Company examined 73 million reviews in three areas: home, legal and medical services. Nearly 14 percent of the reviews were likely fake. The company expressed a "high degree of confidence" that 2.3 million reviews were partly or entirely AI-produced.

Last September, the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) took legal action against the company behind an AI writing tool and content producer called Rytr. The FTC accused Rytr of offering a service that could pollute the marketplace with fake reviews.

The FTC, which banned the sale or purchase of fake reviews in 2024, said some of Rytr's buyers used the tool to produce hundreds and perhaps thousands of reviews. The reviews appeared in support of garage door repair companies, sellers of copied designer handbags and other businesses.

FILE - The Federal Trade Commission building is seen in Washington on Dec. 8, 2024. (AP Photo/Jose Luis Magana)

What are companies doing?

Major companies are developing policies for how AI-generated content fits into their systems for removing fake reviews. Some companies already employ special programs and investigative teams to find and remove fake reviews. Still, the companies are giving users some ability to use AI.

Spokespeople for Amazon and Trustpilot, for example, said they would permit buyers to post AI-assisted reviews as long as the buyers represent their true experience. Yelp has taken a more cautious approach, saying its rules require reviewers to write their own reviews.

The Coalition for Trusted Reviews, which Amazon, Trustpilot, Glassdoor, Tripadvisor, Expedia and Booking.com launched last year, said that even though people may put AI to illegal use, the technology also presents “an opportunity to push back against those who seek to use reviews to mislead others.”

The FTC’s rule banning fake reviews, which took effect in October, permits the agency to fine businesses and individuals who take part in fake reviews. Tech companies hosting such reviews are protected from the penalty. This is because they are not legally responsible under U.S. law for the content that outsiders post on their websites.

Tech companies, including Amazon, Yelp and Google, have sued fake review dealers they accuse of selling fake reviews on their sites. The companies say their technology has blocked or removed a large number of suspect reviews and suspicious accounts. However, some experts say they could be doing more.

“Their efforts thus far are not nearly enough,” said Kay Dean, a former federal criminal investigator who runs a public protection group called Fake Review Watch. “If these tech companies are so committed to eliminating review fraud on their platforms, why is it that I, one individual who works with no automation, can find hundreds or even thousands of fake reviews on any given day?”

Finding fake reviews

Consumers can try to find fake reviews by watching out for a few possible warning signs, researchers say. Overly good or bad reviews are suspect. Highly specialized terms that repeat a product’s full name or model number are another possible clue.

When it comes to AI, research done by Balázs Kovács, a Yale professor, has shown that people cannot tell the difference between AI-created and human-written reviews. Some AI detectors may also be fooled by shorter texts, which are common in online reviews, the study said.

However, there are some AI clues that online shoppers and service seekers should keep in mind. Panagram Labs says reviews written with AI are often longer, highly structured and include “empty descriptors.” Empty descriptors include general phrases and attributes or

characteristics. The writing also often includes overused phrases or opinions like “the first thing that struck me” and “game-changer.”

I'm John Russell.

And I'm Anna Matteo.

Haleluya Hadero reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

review - n. การประเมินหรือการตรวจสอบสินค้าหรือบริการ

opportunity - n. โอกาสที่ดีสำหรับความก้าวหน้า

mislead - v. ชักนำไปในทางที่ผิด หรือทำให้เข้าใจผิด

sue - v. ฟ้องร้องดำเนินคดีตามกฎหมาย

fraud - n. การฉ้อโกง; การเปลี่ยนแปลงความจริงโดยเจตนาเพื่อให้ผู้อื่นสูญเสียสิ่งที่มีค่า

automation - n. ระบบอัตโนมัติ; การทำงานของระบบที่ควบคุมด้วยอุปกรณ์อิเล็กทรอนิกส์แทนแรงงานมนุษย์

clue - n. ร่องรอย; ข้อบ่งชี้ที่นำไปสู่การแก้ปัญหา

detect-- v. ตรวจจับ; ค้นพบธรรมชาติที่แท้จริงของบางสิ่ง; ค้นพบบางสิ่ง

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What new challenge have AI tools for online reviews created for sellers, service providers, and buyers?

- A. A decrease in the overall number of online reviews.
- B. An unfamiliar situation regarding public protection and research.
- C. Improved accuracy and trustworthiness of reviews.
- D. A reduction in the time needed to write genuine reviews.

2. How were false or fake reviews typically managed on popular websites before the widespread use of AI tools?

- A. Businesses directly hired professional writers to create reviews.
- B. Reviews were traded in private social media groups or exchanged for rewards like gift cards.
- C. Websites automatically generated positive reviews for paying businesses.
- D. Customers were paid cash directly for writing positive reviews.

3. According to technology industry experts, what is the primary advantage AI tools, like OpenAI's ChatGPT, offer in the context of producing reviews?

- A. They ensure the reviews are more accurate and truthful.
- B. They allow people to produce reviews faster and in greater numbers.
- C. They help in identifying and removing fake reviews more effectively.
- D. They simplify the process of verifying reviewer identities.

4. Which of the following best describes the range of industries where fake reviews are being found?

- A. Primarily e-commerce and retail.
- B. Limited to travel and hospitality services.
- C. Across a wide range of industries, including e-commerce, travel, home repairs, and medical care.
- D. Only in professional services like legal and medical care.

5. When did The Transparency Company, a public protection group, start observing a large number of AI-generated reviews?

- A. Early 2023.
- B. Mid-2023.
- C. Late 2023.
- D. Early 2024.

6. Based on The Transparency Company's recent report covering 73 million reviews in three service areas, what percentage of reviews were likely fake, and how many were partly or entirely AI-produced with high confidence?

- A. Nearly 14 percent likely fake; 73 million AI-produced.
- B. Less than 10 percent likely fake; 2.3 million AI-produced.
- C. Nearly 14 percent likely fake; 2.3 million partly or entirely AI-produced.
- D. Over 20 percent likely fake; 14 million AI-produced.

7. Which company did the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) take legal action against last September, accusing it of polluting the marketplace with fake reviews?

- A. Amazon.
- B. OpenAI.
- C. Rytr.
- D. The Transparency Company.

8. According to the FTC, for what purpose did some of Rytr's buyers use the AI tool?

- A. To create authentic product descriptions for new businesses.
- B. To produce hundreds or thousands of reviews supporting various businesses, such as garage door repair companies and sellers of copied designer handbags.
- C. To analyze market trends and consumer sentiments.
- D. To develop new AI writing algorithms for review generation.

9. What is the general approach major companies are taking regarding AI-generated content in their systems for removing fake reviews?

- A. They are completely banning all AI-generated content.
- B. They are developing policies for how AI-generated content fits into their systems, while still allowing users some ability to use AI.
- C. They are solely relying on AI tools to detect all fake reviews.
- D. They are ignoring AI-generated content as a negligible threat.

10. How do the policies of Amazon and Trustpilot differ from Yelp's policy regarding AI-assisted reviews?

- A. Amazon and Trustpilot completely ban AI-assisted reviews, while Yelp permits them.
- B. Amazon and Trustpilot permit AI-assisted reviews if they represent true experiences, whereas Yelp requires reviewers to write their own.
- C. Yelp permits AI-assisted reviews with strict moderation, while Amazon and Trustpilot do not.
- D. All three companies have identical policies against any form of AI-generated content.

11. What is the perspective of the Coalition for Trusted Reviews regarding AI technology, despite its potential for illegal use?

- A. AI is solely a tool for misleading consumers.
- B. AI presents an opportunity to counteract those who use reviews to mislead.
- C. AI should be completely banned from review platforms.
- D. AI has no significant impact on review integrity.

12. Under the FTC's rule banning fake reviews, which entities are protected from penalties despite hosting such reviews?

- A. Businesses and individuals who post fake reviews.
- B. Tech companies hosting fake reviews.
- C. Foreign companies operating outside the U.S.
- D. Consumers who unknowingly interact with fake reviews.

13. What legal action have tech companies like Amazon, Yelp, and Google taken in response to fake reviews?

- A. They have sued individual users who posted fake reviews.
- B. They have sued fake review dealers for selling fake reviews on their sites.
- C. They have lobbied the government to relax fake review regulations.
- D. They have partnered with AI companies to generate positive reviews.

14. What is Kay Dean's primary criticism of the tech companies' efforts to eliminate review fraud?

- A. She believes they are not using enough AI in their detection methods.
- B. She thinks their efforts are insufficient, as she, working without automation, can find numerous fake reviews daily.
- C. She argues they are too focused on suing dealers instead of preventing fraud.
- D. She suggests they are deliberately allowing fake reviews for profit.

15. According to researchers, which of the following is a possible warning sign consumers can look for to detect fake reviews?

- A. Reviews that are moderately positive or negative.
- B. Reviews that briefly mention product features.
- C. Overly good or bad reviews, or highly specialized terms repeating a product's full name or model number.
- D. Reviews written by verified purchasers only.